

BIOMASS ENERGY & AI

Reforestation in Mitsue — Ecology · Energy · Digital Infrastructure
v4.6 · 2026-10-08 · Rob Oudendijk

"The forest our ancestors planted — the power that sustains the village they built"

A 25-year initiative to revitalise a village site and the forest that surrounds it

What the Project Is

Transforms a **village site (not yet decided — candidates include vacant school buildings and disused factories; final choice in Phase 1)** and the aging cedar forest nearby into a living model of rural self-sufficiency. Three elements work together:

- **Forest restoration** — Replacing aging sugi monoculture with native species. Thinnings yield biomass fuel; native broadleaf trees feed deer/boar/bear, reducing crop damage
- **Biomass CHP energy** — Sugi thinnings fuel a combined heat & power system (electricity + heat), complemented by solar and EV charging, with backup during outages
- **Sustainable AI data center** — Small, efficient digital facility at a site still to be chosen (e.g. a vacant public building or disused factory), powered entirely by local energy — new infrastructure and jobs

These are not three separate ideas — each one makes the others possible.

Underneath it all: いのち (*inochi*, “life”). The energy from the trees the older generation planted will brighten the lives of their children and grandchildren. The village’s 100-Year Plan “begins with nurturing people and ends with nurturing people.”

The Problems This Project Solves

Challenge	How the Project Responds
Large data centers drain power grids and water	Small, sized to local biomass power: no new grid load, minimal water
Former school/factories vacant	Repurposed as data center & community anchor (site set in Phase 1)
Cedar monoculture, ecologically depleted	Systematic conversion to native mixed forest
Grid dependency, no local power	Biomass CHP from sugi thinnings as primary supply, solar/EV as complement
Shrinking population, no local jobs	Roughly doubling the forestry workforce + data center/energy jobs
Blackouts, wildlife crop damage	On-site biomass power backs up key facilities; restored forest keeps wildlife in the woods

Who Is Behind It

Rob Oudendijk — Dutch electrical engineer, resident of Mitsue since 2012, core hardware developer for [Safecast](#).

Advisors: Ray Ozzie (Blues) · San Poisson · Takuo Dome (Osaka Univ.) · Evin Zoet / Yoshiko Zoet-Suzuki (Transom) · Henry Takata (biomass) A **non-profit** is being established with residents, village leadership, foresters and academics.

Benefits Arrive Well Before Year 25

Timeline	Milestone
Year 1	Site (school/unused factory) activated; international media visibility
Year 2	Landowners begin receiving cedar harvest income
Year 3–4	EV charging stations operational
Year 4–5	Data center operational; local jobs begin
Year 5–10	Data revenue reinvested into village and forest programmes
Year 25	Native forest established; model published worldwide

Financing — Seeking Seed Money

No funding is secured yet. The immediate need is **seed money** to move Phase 0/1 forward (feasibility studies, legal incorporation, early outreach). Once in place, the plan stacks complementary sources: 林野庁 forestry grants · METI/NEDO rural energy grants · village 2/3–3/4 renewable-energy subsidy · FIT/FIP · J-Credit · data center revenue · impact investment.

Current Status

The project is in **Phase 0** — community consultation, feasibility study, non-profit formation. No major commitments have been made. This is the moment to ask questions, raise concerns, and shape what comes next.

How to Get Involved

- **Residents & landowners** — Join the consultation process
- **Foresters & new residents** — Paid roles as the crew doubles (relocation support available)
- **Investors & philanthropists** — Phase 0 seed money
- **Professionals & researchers** — Feasibility input, technical review, collaboration

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"If it works here, it can work elsewhere."

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